

Chapter 104-1

The immersive experience of escape rooms comes from the realistic set designs and live NPCs—whether solving puzzles or completing tasks, everything makes you feel like you're truly there.

Liang Shi had come to play because her former assistant had enthusiastically recommended it, saying the immersive escape room experience was excellent, that it scared her heart into pounding, but it was especially good for releasing stress.

As a result, Sister Wang had glared at her at the time and asked coldly, "What stress do you have?"

Assistant Xiao Bai: "....."

Xiao Bai, whose scalp went numb from Sister Wang's gaze, immediately answered, "None! I went to play a healing-themed one. It was my friend who took me to play the horror dungeon. What stress could I have? I have such a great boss. It was my colleague's boss who was too mean—I was just accompanying her. I came out after passing two stages."

Xiao Bai always had strong survival instincts.

Whenever she encountered such situations, she would frantically flatter Sister Wang.

Liang Shi just sat there watching with a smile, and once Xiao Bai had survived the "boss's trust crisis," she continued her sales pitch.

Although she was a very close assistant, Xiao Bai didn't know that Liang Shi couldn't really handle horror things. On the contrary, Xiao Bai had always thought Liang Shi was very bold.

After all, she was a woman who wasn't afraid of creatures like snakes.

Let alone intangible ghosts.

Xiao Bai naturally assumed that in this world, there was nothing Liang Shi was afraid of.

So when the system issued this task, Liang Shi thought of coming to play an immersive escape room.

After all, she had already watched horror movies at home before—different experiences feel different.

And she had believed Xiao Bai's words.

Xiao Bai had said that even immersive escape rooms had very healing themes, like the Doraemon-themed one she'd played before, where you just had to find clues in rooms. It wasn't scary at all—even the BGM¹ was very soothing, and the NPCs were only responsible for handing them clues. Some were even quite humorous—it was especially suitable for timid people to play.

She had even patted Liang Shi's shoulder at the time and said, "But Sister Liang definitely wouldn't play something so childish."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi had smiled awkwardly and changed the subject at the time.

Dream Castle, as the name suggested, was a castle. There were five other people doing the dungeon with them, making it a relatively large immersive escape room, semi-puzzle-oriented.

Generally, the puzzle and horror levels were inversely proportional—the more puzzles there were, the less horror there would be.

Dungeons that achieved five stars in both puzzles and horror were very, very rare. After all, they had to consider the market, and extremely intelligent people were a minority.

Most people came to play just seeking thrills and the experience—they didn't want to come and have their IQ insulted.

From its exterior, this castle was quite impressive in scale, comparable to a small villa.

A seven-person dungeon meant there would be solo tasks, but Liang Shi didn't know this.

Among the seven people in their group, there were two men and five women. Including Liang Shi, there were two Alphas, four Betas, and one Omega.

That being Xu Qingzhu.

When everyone learned that Xu Qingzhu was an Omega, all their gazes swept over uniformly, and then they saw Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu's joined hands.

A younger girl said, "Are you two a couple? You match so well."

Liang Shi paused for a moment. "We're married."

That girl's eyes immediately turned into hearts.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu didn't mind. After the seven people entered the castle, the castle doors closed, and then a very eerie mechanical voice sounded in the main hall. This voice was somewhat similar to the system's voice—both had that kind of AI prompt sound with static—and it began to introduce the storyline to them.

It was a very long storyline, but the general idea was that a princess was trapped in Dream Castle, and they needed to pass through seven spaces to rescue the princess. Each space would have clues about the princess.

The space they were currently in was the first one—there were lights, and everything was pink.

This kind of environment gave people a very warm and cozy feeling.

The furnishings here felt like a princess's bedroom, with a bed and cabinets.

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Among them, one was an experienced escape room player who would remind them what to pay attention to inside the escape room. Another was an expert at tearing places apart—when searching for evidence, she would basically turn every corner upside down.

And Xu Qingzhu's good logical ability and powerful calculation skills allowed them to quickly crack codes.

The first three stages were very easy to pass, and they didn't encounter any particularly scary NPCs. Everyone had lowered their guard.

After the third stage ended, they took the elevator to go to the second floor. A girl said, "This is supposed to be a five-star horror dungeon? That staff member must have been lying."

"We can ask him for a refund later," another person said. "Where's the horror in this?"

They were still discussing when suddenly, the lights in the elevator went out. There was no light at all.

The elevator hung suspended, and everyone was startled.

Liang Shi gripped Xu Qingzhu tightly, pulling her directly into her arms, even though her calves had trembled the instant the elevator fell into darkness.

The warm breath from Xu Qingzhu's breathing spread onto her skin. Liang Shi asked in a low voice, "Are you okay?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "I'm fine."

Meanwhile, the people trapped in the elevator immediately started chattering, "Is this the fourth stage?"

"Damn, is this really necessary?"

"We haven't lost anyone, right?"

"No... hey, who tapped my back?"

"I didn't move."

"Neither did I."

Suddenly, a faint glow emanated from a corner of the elevator, and from somewhere came an ethereal voice: "It was me who tapped you."

A childish voice, accompanied by laughter that sent chills down one's spine: "I like you all so much. Can one of you come play hide-and-seek with me?"

"What does this mean?" Liang Shi gripped Xu Qingzhu's wrist, her voice trembling slightly but still holding on. "Is she giving us a clue?"

Although it was her first time playing an escape room, Liang Shi had done her homework beforehand—whenever an NPC appeared, there would definitely be important clues.

The experienced escape room player said, "She's looking for someone to do a solo task."

"The princess is so bored." That childish voice continued to sound in the small space. "Really, no one wants to play with me? Then I'm going to punish you all!"

"Five, four..."

She started counting down, and when she reached 2, that experienced player raised her hand and said she was willing to go.

Then a deep, dark corridor opened up from the side of the elevator, like a mechanism.

Footnotes:

¹ BGM: Short for "background music," commonly used in gaming and entertainment contexts to refer to the ambient music playing during an experience.